

Reported Speech — Questions & Commands

B2 · Upper-Intermediate · Report what someone asked or told someone to do, not just what they said.

You already know how to report statements. Real conversations also include questions and commands — reporting those needs a different structure, not just the same backshift rule.

Rules

a) Reporting yes/no questions

Use **if** or **whether**, and switch back to normal statement word order (no auxiliary inversion).

- "Do you like coffee?" → She asked if I liked coffee.
- "Are you coming?" → He asked whether I was coming.

b) Reporting wh- questions

Keep the question word, but use normal statement word order.

- "Where do you live?" → She asked where I lived.
- "What time is it?" → He asked what time it was.

c) Reporting commands and requests

tell/ask + object + (not) + to-infinitive — no backshifting needed, since the infinitive doesn't change.

- "Close the door." → She told me to close the door.
- "Please don't be late." → He asked me not to be late.

Examples

- She asked if I liked coffee.
- He asked whether I was coming.
- She asked where I lived.
- He asked what time it was.
- She told me to close the door.

- He asked me not to be late.

Common Mistakes

× She asked did I like coffee.

✓ She asked if I liked coffee.

Reported yes/no questions need "if/whether" and normal word order, not the original question form.

× He asked where did I live.

✓ He asked where I lived.

Reported wh- questions keep the question word but drop the auxiliary inversion.

× She told me close the door.

✓ She told me to close the door.

Reported commands need "to" before the infinitive.

× He asked me to not be late.

✓ He asked me not to be late.

The negative goes before "to," not between "to" and the verb.

Summary

- Yes/no questions → if/whether + normal word order.
- Wh- questions → keep the question word + normal word order.
- Commands/requests → tell/ask + object + (not) to-infinitive.

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